

Bayesian Spam Filters

Bayesian spam filters calculate the probability of a message being spam, based on its content. Unlike simple content-based filters that categorise e-mail by specific words or phrases, Bayesian spam filters 'learn' from a

specific user's e-mail, and build a list

of characteristics to look out for. The characteristics the filter looks at need

not only be the words in the message body and its headers, but also other aspects such as HTML code, or even word pairs and phrases. These filters tweak themselves and get better with time as the list is built up. As the filters get trained specifically for every user, spammers will have an even harder time working around spam filters. These filters can adapt to almost everything spammers try. Spammers will only make it past

well-trained Bayesian filters if they make their messages look perfectly like an ordinary e-mail. The chance of returning false positives i.e., wrong classification of legitimate e-mail as spam, is minimal.

This results in a more robust and efficient way of spam detection.

The user starts with e-mails that he has classified as spam, and another bunch of legitimate e-mails. The filters look at both, and analyse the legitimate e-mails, as well as the spam, to calculate the probability of various characteristics appearing in spam, and in normal e-mails.

appropriate network administrator. You can also use various other tools such as the Spam IDentifier found at www.spamid.net that looks up the owners of an IP address or domain name.

A whole lot of tools that trace and report the spamming culprits are also available at www.spamabuse.org.

Remove-Spam (www.remove-spam.com) has spam reporting services that offer manual tracking and reporting of your spam on a per-report or monthly fee basis.

If you have Microsoft Outlook, you can also use Spam Control found at www.hendricom.com/spamcontrol.htm, which is a reporting tool that forwards spam to a reporting organisation.

SPAM Punisher (www.spampunisher.com) is also a useful program that assists with creating complaints about received spam.

Spam Do's and Don'ts

There are a few things that you can do at your end to evade spam. Never make lists of e-mail addresses, and if you do, do not e-mail the list: Many people pass on jokes and other interesting stuff to their list of friends. Some of them pass it on to their own contacts, and the list keeps on increasing. While this may be acceptable to the recipients, it would be the perfect way for a spammer to get a list of valid e-mail IDs of a large number of people at one go. One alternative around this is to send the e-mails separately, so that a single message does not contain many e-mail IDs.

If a spammer receives even one response among the thousands sent out, it is enough. If you reply to a message, the spam will know that your e-mail ID is valid, and continue spamming. In addition, once the spammers know that your e-mail ID is legitimate, they can sell your address to other spammers, kicking off a chain.

An important point to remember is to never respond to the

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